

164 Priscilla and Aquila

A tentmaking couple who opened their home to Paul, taught Apollos, and risked their lives for the gospel.

Priscilla and Aquila were a Jewish couple who made tents for a living. Forced out of Rome by the emperor Claudius, they settled in Corinth, where Paul lived and worked with them. They later moved with him to Ephesus, where they quietly explained the way of God more fully to the gifted preacher Apollos. Wherever they lived, a church met in their house. Paul said they had risked their own necks for his life. They are never mentioned apart, and often Priscilla is named first. Their story shows how ordinary work, a shared home and a steady marriage can serve the gospel.

At a glance

Names	Priscilla (Prisca, 2 Timothy 4:19) and her husband Aquila
Origin	Aquila was a Jew "born in Pontus" (Acts 18:2)
Work	Tentmakers, the same trade as Paul (Acts 18:3)
When	c. AD 49 to the AD 60s
Homes	Rome, Corinth, Ephesus, then Rome again
Key people	Paul, Apollos, Timothy
Main passages	Acts 18:1–3, 18–26; Romans 16:3–5
Also in	1 Corinthians 16:19; 2 Timothy 4:19

"Greet Priscilla and Aquila my helpers in Christ Jesus: Who have for my life laid down their own necks."

Romans 16:3–4, KJV

The life of Priscilla and Aquila

Dates are approximate (AD) and follow Paul's journeys. The date of Claudius's order comes from Roman writers, not from Acts.

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| c. AD 49
<i>Rome</i> | ● Forced out
The emperor Claudius orders all Jews to leave Rome. Aquila and Priscilla move east to Corinth. Acts does not say whether they already believed in Jesus. <i>Acts 18:2</i> |
| c. AD 50
<i>Corinth</i> | ● Paul moves in
Paul arrives from Athens and finds them. Because they share the same trade, he lives and works with them while reasoning in the synagogue every sabbath. He stays in Corinth eighteen months. <i>Acts 18:1-4, 11</i> |
| c. AD 52
<i>Cenchrea to Ephesus</i> | ● Sail with Paul
When Paul leaves Corinth, Priscilla and Aquila sail with him as far as Ephesus. Paul travels on, and they stay behind. <i>Acts 18:18-19</i> |
| c. AD 52
<i>Ephesus</i> | ● Teach Apollos
They hear the eloquent preacher Apollos speak boldly in the synagogue. They take him aside and explain "the way of God more perfectly." <i>Acts 18:24-26</i> |
| c. AD 53-55
<i>Ephesus</i> | ● A church in their house
Writing from Ephesus, Paul sends greetings from Aquila and Priscilla "with the church that is in their house." <i>1 Corinthians 16:8, 19</i> |
| c. AD 57
<i>Rome</i> | ● Back home
Paul greets them in Rome, praising them as helpers who risked their lives for him. Again a church meets in their house. <i>Romans 16:3-5</i> |
| c. AD 64-67
<i>Probably Ephesus</i> | ● Still remembered
In his last letter Paul sends greetings to "Prisca and Aquila." Timothy, who receives the letter, seems to be in Ephesus. <i>2 Timothy 4:19</i> |

Key activities

The couple are always named together. In several verses Priscilla comes first, which was unusual at the time. Some think she was the more prominent in the church; others suggest she came from a higher social rank. Manuscripts differ on the order in Acts 18:26.

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- 1 **Started over.** Forced from Rome, they rebuilt their home and business in Corinth. *Acts 18:2-3*
 - 2 **Took Paul in.** They gave him lodging and shared their work with him. *Acts 18:3*
 - 3 **Moved for the gospel.** They went with Paul to Ephesus and stayed there. *Acts 18:18-19*
 - 4 **Taught Apollos privately.** Rather than correcting him in public, "they took him unto them, and expounded unto him the way of God more perfectly." *Acts 18:26*
 - 5 **Hosted churches.** Believers met in their home in Ephesus and in Rome. *1 Corinthians 16:19; Romans 16:5*
 - 6 **Risked their lives for Paul.** They "laid down their own necks" for him. Scripture does not say when or where. *Romans 16:4*
 - 7 **Earned the thanks of many churches.** Paul says all the churches of the Gentiles gave thanks for them. *Romans 16:4*
 - 8 **Stayed faithful to the end.** Paul still sent them greetings in his final letter. *2 Timothy 4:19*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links; the couple is not named in the Old Testament.

Old Testament

Echo: Exodus 31:1–6	Bezalel and skilled workers serve God with their hands
Echo: Ecclesiastes 4:9	"Two are better than one"

New Testament

Acts 18:1–3	Tentmakers with Paul in Corinth
Acts 18:18–19, 26	They sail to Ephesus and teach Apollos
1 Corinthians 16:19	Greetings "with the church that is in their house"
Romans 16:3–5	Helpers who risked their lives; a church in Rome
2 Timothy 4:19	"Salute Prisca and Aquila"; Paul's authorship debated
Echo: 1 Thessalonians 2:9	Paul works so as not to burden the church

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Priscilla and Aquila do when they heard Apollos teach (Acts 18:26)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think they corrected Apollos privately?
3. *Apply:* How could your ordinary work or home open a door for someone this week?
4. *Apply:* Who has invested in you as this couple did in Apollos? How could you pass it on?